



United States
Attorney's Office
Eastern District of California



Fresno County Podiatrist and Sales Representative Indicted for Conspiracy to Submit Millions of Dollars in False Claims Related to Skin Grafts

Thursday, April 10, 2025

For Immediate Release

U.S. Attorney's Office, Eastern District of California

FRESNO, Calif. — A federal grand jury returned a one-count indictment today against Felipe Ruiz, 51, of Fresno, and Jose Gabriel Aguirre, 52, of Clovis, charging them with conspiracy to commit health care fraud, Acting U.S. Attorney Michele Beckwith announced.

According to court documents, Ruiz was a podiatrist at West Coast Podiatry Inc. (WCP), a podiatric medical practice with locations in Fresno, Madera, and Stanislaus Counties.

Aguirre was a sales representative for several companies that sold skin grafts. Aguirre used his name, his wife's name, and the name of a corporation registered to his wife to sell the skin grafts.

Between June 2021 and January 2024, Ruiz purchased skin grafts from Aguirre and permitted Aguirre, who was not a licensed health care provider, to apply the skin grafts to Medicare and Medi-Cal beneficiaries without Ruiz being present. Ruiz and Aguirre also allowed beneficiaries to refer to Aguirre as "Dr. Gabe," though he was not a doctor.

Ruiz and Aguirre subsequently submitted claims to Medicare and Medi-Cal that falsely represented that Ruiz had applied the skin grafts to the beneficiaries, when Aguirre had actually rendered the services. As a result, Medicare and Medi-Cal paid Ruiz millions of dollars for the false claims. Ruiz then made payments to Aguirre. Ruiz and Aguirre used the money for their own benefit and for personal expenditures.

This case is the product of an investigation by the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services Office of Inspector General and the Federal Bureau of Investigation. Assistant U.S. Attorney Brittany M.

Gunter is prosecuting the case.

If convicted, Ruiz and Aguirre face a maximum penalty of 10 years in prison and a \$250,000 fine. Any sentence, however, would be determined at the discretion of the court after consideration of any applicable statutory factors and the Federal Sentencing Guidelines, which take into account a number of variables. The charges are only allegations; the defendants are presumed innocent until and unless proven guilty beyond a reasonable doubt.

Updated April 11, 2025

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